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Routing right

Setting up a network can sometimes be a burden and it seems Agent 001 faced one recently

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So there I was with a few friends watching Ender's Game and one of my them springs a "tech question", something about setting up a router at his place. Now that's a pretty quick job and shouldn't take a few minutes after all it's something I end up doing every other month or so and even more frequently at the Digit Test Centre. So began our journey and the first step was to get a lay of the land i.e. check his place out. I took my router along and we shortlisted a few spots around the house where there was a phone jack in close proximity and we started off one by one.

At each spot, the router was placed and the signal strength was measured at different places throughout the house. My pesky little router is an ancient Linksys WAG200G router, something that has lasted me ages and was accessible from all corners of my home. Unfortunately, this place was a bit weirdly designed and one of the bedrooms couldn't manage to keep a connection for long. On top of that, my friend's mom was pretty adamant of not having an ugly router bang in the centre of her home and we simply couldn't go against the lady of the house – thus began a dilemma.

My first approach was to move the router to another location and see if that helped, there would be some difference but nothing significant. That damned room must've had lead walls. So my friend starts throwing a few suggestions around about how a higher power router might do the job. I'd heard this before and it's a common approach when a certain

thing doesn't work/fit/open then you use more force and make it happen. It doesn't work that way for routers, a high transmit power just makes the signal more prominent but that's just part of the entire picture and since these values are restricted based on your region you might not get any device that has more than the permitted threshold.

Let's say your router allows you to increase the transmit power to 200mW and if you still can't get a proper signal in a particular room then you are at a disadvantage. Which means the only way to increase the output would be to get high gain antenna which are directional. Since that would require a lot more searching and frankly wouldn't be worth the effort I picked up a few routers from the Test Centre to see if that helped. The following conditions had to be met,

- ADSL support
- 802.11n support
- Removable antenna
- Budget friendly
- High-gain antenna if possible

There were two mid-range models (N600DB and TD-W8968) lying around and I took them both. We tried the N600DB first and it did work well though the mysterious bedroom didn't

have that good a signal strength. However, this router would have put my friend back by around ₹6,499 which isn't too high but he wasn't willing to put that much down. The other option was the TD-W8968 which compared to my ancient router was way better. With that we were able to connect to the network but there were connection drops which again was a bother.

Desperate times call for desperate measures and we went out and got an extension cable similar to the one pictured here. It was 10 metres long and cost about a 1000 bucks. We hooked the router up and removed one of the antennae. The cable was attached to the router and then the wire was routed outside the house and dropped into the bedroom with the antenna attached to it.

Finally! We had a fairly good signal strength not only inside the bedroom but throughout the home and no complaints from the lady of the house. At the end of the two weeks we managed to get a good setup working for less than ₹4,000 that too without compromising on quality. While there haven't been any complaints so far, it won't be long before I'll get another troubleshooting call. Till then, buh-bye! 



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